Answer key and explanations

Unit 1, Day 1: What Happens When You Stop Seeking Approval

Quick key

Section	Answers
ACT Reading	1: A · 2: J · 3: A · 4: F · 5: A · 6: G · 7: A · 8: G · 9: A · 10: G
SAT Reading and Writing	1: A · 2: A · 3: A · 4: C · 5: A · 6: A · 7: A · 8: B · 9: A · 10: C
ACT English	11: B · 12: J · 13: C
GRE Verbal Reasoning	1: B · 2: independent of / accounted for · 3: A, B · 4: A, B · 5: A, B · 6: 4 · 7: B
FAST ELA Reading	1, Part A: A · 1, Part B: A, C · 2: A, C · 3: A

Section 1: ACT Reading

1. A MAIN IDEA

Main-idea questions cover the whole passage. Eliminate any choice that describes only one paragraph or that the passage explicitly rejects.

- **A (correct).** Correct. Paragraph 2 announces the plan ("in the order it happens"), Paragraphs 3–8 carry it out, and Paragraph 10 gives the first steps.
- **B.** Too narrow. Schopenhauer supplies one opening line and the closing echo. The passage does not summarize his philosophy.
- **C.** Contradicted. Paragraph 9: "A man who ignores every voice isn't free. He's just deaf."
- **D.** Too narrow. The Crocker study is one piece of evidence in one paragraph.

2. J DETAIL (EXCEPT)

On EXCEPT questions, confirm three choices in the text. The one you cannot find is the answer. Here the trap is a choice that sounds like it belongs with the others.

- **F.** Stated: "They reported more stress and more anger."
- **G.** Stated: "They drank and used drugs more."
- **H.** Stated directly.
- **J (correct).** Correct. The passage never says this. It says the links held after researchers accounted for overall self-esteem, which is the opposite of naming low self-esteem as the cause.

3. A VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

Replace the word with each choice and reread the sentence before and after it. The surrounding contrast decides the meaning, not the most common definition.

- **A (correct).** Correct. The contrast is between how much confidence the students had and where it was located: in other people's hands.
- **B.** Wrong sense. Nothing is being postponed.
- **C.** Wrong sense, as in a store. Not supported by the context.
- **D.** Overread. The passage is about location, not secrecy.

4. F FUNCTION OF A PARAGRAPH

A paragraph's function is usually stated in the author's interpretation after the evidence. Read past the study to the sentence that says what it means.

- **F (correct).** Correct. The study is followed by its interpretation ("Something they did out of love had turned into something they did for a ribbon") and then applied to work.
- **G.** Overread. No school is criticized.
- **H.** Wrong paragraph. That idea appears in Paragraph 8.
- **J.** Contradicted: "They hadn't stopped being able to draw."

5. A INFERENCE

An inference is one short step from the text. If a choice adds a cause the paragraph never mentions, it is too far.

- **A (correct).** Correct. "They lost a version of you that was built to please them."
- **B.** Not supported. The changes listed are withdrawals (no longer agreeing, saying yes, laughing), not rudeness.
- **C.** Not mentioned anywhere in the paragraph.
- **D.** Not supported. No criticism is described.

6. G AUTHOR'S VIEW

Attitude questions often hinge on a qualifier. The right answer here keeps the limit the author sets: a few trusted people.

- **F.** Opposite. The author says a strong man "actively hunts" for it.
- **G (correct).** Correct. Paragraph 9 limits it to "the few people whose judgment he has earned reason to trust."
- **H.** Contradicted by "actively hunts for the second."
- **J.** The author takes a clear position.

7. A CAUSE AND EFFECT

Find the sentence with the cause. On the ACT, the answer is usually a close paraphrase of a single line.

- **A (correct).** Correct. "The more obviously you depend on someone's approval, the more they suspect your praise and agreement are a strategy."
- **B.** Not mentioned.
- **C.** Not mentioned.
- **D.** Not supported. The passage is about visible need, not sincerity.

8. G COMPARISON

When an author defines a contrast, use the author's definition. Outside facts that happen to be true do not score.

- **F.** Outside knowledge. The passage gives a different reason.
- **G (correct).** Correct. The because-clause defines the contrast: "a servant can quit, but a man who needs approval carries his master everywhere."
- **H.** Not stated.
- **J.** Literal misreading of a figure of speech.

9. A ORGANIZATION

Look for signal words. Ordinal words (first, second, last) mark a sequence.

- **A (correct).** Correct. "The first thing…The second thing…" through "the last thing."
- **B.** Wrong structure. Paragraph 9 contains a caution, but 3–8 are not objections.
- **C.** Not present.
- **D.** The studies support different stages. They do not compete.

10. G PURPOSE OF A PARAGRAPH

Endings that echo the opening are framing devices. Name both the echo and what it restates.

- **F.** No study appears in the final paragraph.
- **G (correct).** Correct. It begins "Schopenhauer was right" and repeats "in your own skin."
- **H.** No concession appears.
- **J.** Crocker is not mentioned in the last paragraph.

Section 2: SAT Reading and Writing

1. A WORDS IN CONTEXT

Read the sentence after the blank. "Backfire" tells you the listener sees the praise as calculated.

- **A (correct).** Correct. The listener suspects the praise is calculated, which is why it backfires.
- **B.** Praise already is a compliment. The word adds no suspicion, so the logic of "backfire" breaks.
- **C.** Suspicion of a coincidence makes no sense with "depend on someone's approval."
- **D.** Nothing in the text suggests the praise costs the speaker anything.

2. A TEXT STRUCTURE AND PURPOSE

Function questions ask what a sentence does, not what it says. Signal phrases like "be careful here" often introduce a qualification.

- **A (correct).** Correct. "Be careful here" signals a limit, and the sentence sets it.
- **B.** No study is cited in this text.
- **C.** It narrows the claim. It does not reverse it.
- **D.** It describes the opposite extreme, someone who ignores everyone.

3. A CENTRAL IDEAS AND DETAILS

A main idea states the claim, not the topic. Choice D names the topic. Choice A states what the evidence shows.

- **A (correct).** Correct. It combines the result with the text's interpretation in its last two sentences.
- **B.** Skill is never measured. The text says ability did not change.
- **C.** Not supported. The text describes time spent drawing, not preferences.
- **D.** True but only a topic. It does not state the finding.

4. C COMMAND OF EVIDENCE (TEXTUAL)

Find the two parts of the claim (where, not how much) and pick the evidence that addresses both. A true detail that addresses only one part is a trap.

- **A.** Describes the study's method, not its finding.
- **B.** Shows how common the pattern was, not what caused the harm.
- **C (correct).** Correct. It separates the amount of self-esteem from where it was placed, which is exactly the claim.
- **D.** Shows harm existed, but not its cause.

5. A INFERENCES

"Because…had not lost the ability" rules out one explanation. The right answer is the one that remains.

- **A (correct).** Correct. With ability ruled out, the remaining explanation is motivation.
- **B.** Contradicted: they "already loved drawing."
- **C.** Unsupported. The comparison group had the same markers and drew more.
- **D.** Skill is not measured.

6. A CROSS-TEXT CONNECTIONS

Find the line in Text 2 that addresses the same subject as Text 1, then predict the response from that line alone.

- **A (correct).** Correct. "Don't make a refusal blunt and final… Give a real reason."
- **B.** Opposite of Text 2.
- **C.** Contradicted: "A gilded no is more satisfactory than a dry yes."
- **D.** Text 2 does not discuss discomfort.

7. A RHETORICAL SYNTHESIS

Read the goal first. "Main finding" eliminates every choice that does not include a result.

- **A (correct).** Correct. It states the finding and gives enough context for a newcomer.
- **B.** Names the researchers but omits the finding.
- **C.** Background only.
- **D.** Describes the setup, not the result.

8. B TRANSITIONS

Decide the relationship between the two sentences before reading the choices: addition, contrast, example, or result.

- **A.** Signals contrast, but the second sentence strengthens the first.
- **B (correct).** Correct. The second sentence adds a further, stronger point.
- **C.** The second sentence is not an example of the first.
- **D.** Nothing is being replaced.

9. A BOUNDARIES

Check whether each side can stand alone as a sentence. If both can, use a comma plus FANBOYS, or a semicolon alone.

- **A (correct).** Correct. Two independent clauses joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction.
- **B.** Missing the comma before the conjunction joining two independent clauses.
- **C.** A semicolon already joins the clauses. Adding "but" after it is not the standard pattern.
- **D.** The comma after "but" wrongly separates the conjunction from its clause.

10. C FORM, STRUCTURE, AND SENSE

Skip the long modifier ("whose self-worth rested on…") to find the true subject: students.

- **A.** Singular verb. The subject is "students," which is plural.
- **B.** Singular verb with a plural subject.
- **C (correct).** Correct. It agrees with "students" and matches the past tense of the study.
- **D.** Singular helping verb.

Section 3: ACT English

11. B SENTENCE BOUNDARIES

If both sides of a comma are complete sentences, the comma alone is a splice.

- **A.** Comma splice: two complete sentences joined by only a comma.
- **B (correct).** Correct. It separates two independent clauses.
- **C.** Run-on sentence.
- **D.** Changes the meaning. "Which" would refer to "you."

12. J REDUNDANCY

The ACT rewards concision. When a phrase repeats what the sentence already says, cut it.

- **F.** Redundant. "Got their award" already says it.
- **G.** Still redundant.
- **H.** Redundant and vague.
- **J (correct).** Correct. The shortest grammatical choice that keeps the meaning.

13. C RELEVANCE

Add-or-delete questions test focus. A true fact that does not serve the paragraph's purpose should be left out.

- **A.** True fact, but it does not serve the paragraph's point.
- **B.** His birthplace explains nothing about his ideas.
- **C (correct).** Correct. The paragraph is about the cost of needing approval, not biography.
- **D.** There is no contradiction. 1788 is his birth, and the 1850s are when he wrote the essay.

Section 4: GRE Verbal Reasoning

1. B TEXT COMPLETION (ONE BLANK)

Predict a word before looking: the blank must name the quality that makes praise unbelievable. "Eager to please" points to obsequious.

- **A.** Opposite. A candid speaker's praise would be believed.
- **B (correct).** Correct. Excessively eager to please, which is exactly what makes praise suspect.
- **C.** Reserved. Quietness does not make praise less believable.
- **D.** Opposite. Impartiality would make praise more credible.
- **E.** Brief in speech. Unrelated to the logic of the sentence.

2. Blank (i): independent of; Blank (ii): accounted for TEXT COMPLETION (TWO BLANKS)

Both blanks must be right to earn credit. Solve the second blank first if it is clearer, then check that the first one agrees with it.

- **independent of.** Correct. The harm did not depend on the level of self-esteem.
- **caused by.** Contradicts the colon's explanation.
- **identical to.** Makes no sense: difficulties cannot be identical to self-esteem.
- **ignored.** Ignoring the variable would prove nothing.
- **accounted for.** Correct. It mirrors the passage: the links held "after the researchers accounted for" self-esteem.
- **exaggerated.** Not supported by the logic.

3. A, B SENTENCE EQUIVALENCE

Both words must fit the sentence and mean nearly the same thing. A word that fits but has no partner is a trap.

- **A (correct).** Correct, paired with hollow.
- **B (correct).** Correct, paired with empty.
- **C.** Opposite of the sentence's logic.
- **D.** Contradicts "rather than winning respect."
- **E.** Unrelated to agreement.
- **F.** Opposite.

4. A, B SENTENCE EQUIVALENCE

The colon explains the blank. "Ignores every voice" points to heedlessness and obliviousness.

- **A (correct).** Correct. Paying no attention.
- **B (correct).** Correct. Being unaware or not listening.
- **C.** Does not match "ignores every voice."
- **D.** Unrelated.
- **E.** Opposite. Deference means yielding to others' views.
- **F.** Fits loosely but has no matching partner.

5. A, B READING COMPREHENSION (SELECT ALL THAT APPLY)

No partial credit. Each choice is judged on its own, and any number of the three may be correct.

- **A (correct).** Correct. Paragraph 4: "a few people may pull away."
- **B (correct).** Correct. Paragraph 5: "you get your energy back."
- **C.** Not stated. The passage separates self-esteem level from where worth is placed.

6. 4 READING COMPREHENSION (SELECT IN PASSAGE)

Look for the sentence that gives a reason, usually marked with because. Distinguish the explanation from a summary of it.

- **1.** Explains when flattery fails, not why agreement is believable.
- **2.** Explains the failure of flattery.
- **3.** Introduces the contrast without explaining it.
- **4 (correct).** Correct. The because-clause gives the reason.
- **5.** Close, but it restates the idea as a summary. The question asks for the sentence about agreement specifically.

7. B READING COMPREHENSION (ARGUMENT)

Find the gap in the argument. Here it is the jump from children drawing to adults working. The weakener targets that gap.

- **A.** This is part of the study's design and strengthens it.
- **B (correct).** Correct. It attacks the leap from preschool children to adult work.
- **C.** That is the comparison group the study needs.
- **D.** This supports the author's comparison.
- **E.** Consistent with the author's view.

Section 5: FAST ELA Reading

1, Part A. A CENTRAL IDEA (EVIDENCE-BASED SELECTED RESPONSE)

Part A and Part B are linked. If Part A is wrong, Part B usually cannot be right.

- **A (correct).** Correct. It is developed across Paragraphs 5, 6, and 7.
- **B.** Contradicted in Paragraph 9.
- **C.** Opposite of Paragraph 8.
- **D.** The passage ends "Schopenhauer was right."

1, Part B. A, C SUPPORTING EVIDENCE (SELECT TWO)

Each selected sentence must support the specific central idea in Part A.

- **A (correct).** Correct. Shows the cost to energy.
- **B.** Background date only.
- **C (correct).** Correct. Shows the cost to the quality of work.
- **D.** A transition with no content.
- **E.** Introduces a concept about respect, not the costs in Part A.

2. A, C FIGURATIVE LANGUAGE (SELECT TWO)

Figurative language says one thing in terms of another. Test each phrase by asking whether it is literally true.

- **A (correct).** Correct. A metaphor: the need for approval is a master he cannot leave.
- **B.** Literal description of a study.
- **C (correct).** Correct. A metaphor for constant judgment.
- **D.** Literal time reference.
- **E.** Literal description of the award.

3. A AUTHOR'S DEVELOPMENT OF A CLAIM

"How does the author develop" asks for the method: the kind of evidence and how it is used.

- **A (correct).** Correct. The ingratiator's dilemma, then the explanation.
- **B.** No personal story appears.
- **C.** No such survey is mentioned.
- **D.** Schopenhauer is quoted only about existence and opinion.

FAST Writing: what a 4 does with these two sources

It takes a side in the first paragraph. A strong claim is that a refusal should include a reason when the reason is true, because Source 2 shows that a warm, explained no preserves respect ("A gilded no is more satisfactory than a dry yes"), while Source 1's bare no is a one-time exercise for breaking the habit of over-explaining ("say no once without an excuse"). It addresses the counterclaim from Source 1 directly, using the word "once" and the distinction between an honest reason and an excuse meant to keep someone's approval. Each quotation is followed by a sentence explaining how it proves the point.